Once before, in Gujarat, the Mughal troops had been caught unawares by an enemy's delayed arrival. The Fuladis were fighting Aziz, and Badauni explains how Sher Khan Fuladi was held up for 'a whole watch at the latrines', being an avid consumer of opium and 'constipation . . . like a hand-grip' a necessary concomitant of his addiction.

Abul Fazl provides no such colourful explanation for the Fuladis' ally, Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk's late arrival, though he does offer the superfluous comment that the sight of 5000 men descending upon them in clouds of dust brought '[a]gitation . . . [to] the brows of' Akbar's tired troops. The imperial drummer was so petrified he couldn't make himself play to rally the men; only the threat of a spear in his side made him oblige.

And Akbar? It seems as if he felt something of that lightness of hand he once described, the feeling of having made a good shot. He was filled with 'a wondrous exultation', writes Abul Fazl, 'like a raging tiger who in the exuberance of his youth essays his force and fierceness'. He was born against the odds, after all; the odds could not kill him.

Earlier that morning, Akbar had told his men that God was on his side. Others might call it luck, but there was a magic touch to Akbar's destiny. Once, it was a stray arrow that pierced Hemu's eye. Now, it was cactus that tripped Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk's horse, sending its rider flying to the ground. He was found by an imperial soldier, who cut off his head.

Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk's vast army fell into the usual disarray. The panic was so 'disgraceful', in fact, that Nizamuddin says the Mughals were taking arrows from the quivers of their enemies to shoot them with. The man who had caught and killed Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk arrived with the Gujarati's head 'tucked . . .
in his skirt',[60] and threw it at Akbar's feet. Delighted, the padishah ordered all the enemy heads stacked in a tower; over 2000 such trophies, writes Nizamuddin, rose in a fearful monument to victory.

In the chaos of the second assault, Abul Fazl writes that two of Akbar's Rajput generals, Bhagwant Das and Rai Raisingh, persuaded the padishah to execute Mirza Muhammad Husain. Both Nizamuddin and Badauni, however, suggest that Rai Raisingh's men took it upon themselves to kill the Mirza, throwing him off an elephant and stabbing him to death. Perhaps they feared Muhammad Husain's quick tongue would save him, and they